

not be jealous of what other people have when what she has is great. He then immediately sees their neighbor with a new pizza oven and takes the family to the store to buy the exact same one. We can know all the right things to say and do, but we are all prone to the feeling that “the grass is greener on the other side,” especially if that side has pizza.

This is also true of the people our friends are connected to. You’ve probably heard the saying “You’re the sum of the five people you spend the most time with,” but it goes even further than that. A thirty-year study on smoking² found that smoking behavior spreads through not just close friends but also distant social ties, up to three degrees of separation. This shows that we’re influenced by our friends’ behaviors and the behaviors of their friends. The same went for the people in the study who stopped smoking. The more people around them who stopped, the more likely they would stop. This study ended in 2003, prior to social media, and we’re guessing the circle is even wider now. Social media has given us the gift of connection, but it’s also given us a lot more people to compare ourselves to.

When you see dozens of people on social media with some new cup, skin-care product, or a cool new pizza oven, you’re more likely to also buy it. We want to belong, and we want to know we’re making good decisions, often using the metric of “What are other people doing?” None of this is bad, but sometimes it leads to decisions that are not in *our* best interest.

In order to practice values-based spending, we need to acknowledge that we’re not practicing it in isolation. The people around us will have a huge impact, both positively and negatively, in how we spend. And there’s no one right way to deal with this. The financial responsibility you have for one family member will be different for another. The way you build boundaries with one friend may be different than what it looks like with others. All our relationships are pushing and pulling us in various spending directions, so it’s important to realize what our community is comprised of and the ways we can make shifts in each relationship to ensure our spending stays aligned with what we value.

Spending in Community

Before we talk about the nuance of relationships and how they impact our spending, there are three foundational concepts we must take into every